ENT Service Line Handbook

MERIDIAN HEALTH PARTNERS
OPERATIONS POLICY DIRECTIVE
DOCUMENT ID: MHP-ENT-SH-042
SUBJECT: Otorhinolaryngology (ENT) Department Service Line Handbook
EFFECTIVE DATE: October 1, 2024
APPLIES TO: All 14 Meridian Health Partners outpatient sites

1. Purpose and Scope

1.1 This handbook defines the operational standards, appointment parameters, clinical scope boundaries, and insurance plan coverages for the Otorhinolaryngology (ENT) department at Meridian Health Partners.

1.2 All scheduling staff, intake coordinators, and billing specialists must adhere to the parameters set forth in this document.

2. Service Access and Scheduling Commitments

2.1 First Appointment Offer Commitment: The ENT department shall offer a first appointment to a patient within 6 calendar days of an accepted referral.
2.2 Referral Turnaround: Clinic-wide referral processing turnaround times are governed exclusively by the Referral Management Policy (MHP-REF-001); staff shall consult that policy for intake validation windows rather than applying separate department-level timelines.

3. Conditions Accepted and Explicitly Not Accepted

3.1 Accepted Conditions: The ENT department accepts adult and pediatric patients presenting with chronic rhinosinusitis, hearing loss, acoustic trauma, nasal septal deviation, chronic otitis media, vocal cord disorders, and obstructive sleep apnea requiring surgical or conservative outpatient management. 3.2 Explicitly Not Accepted Conditions: The ENT department strictly does not accept patients presenting with acute head and neck trauma requiring emergency department intervention, active malignant neoplasms of the skull base requiring primary radiation or inpatient chemotherapy, or congenital tracheo-esophageal fistulae in neonates under 30 days of age. Such presentations must be redirected immediately to regional tertiary acute-care facilities.

4. Appointment Durations

4.1 The ENT department's services run between 20 and 90 minutes.
4.2 Standard appointment durations by service code are defined as follows:
* ENT-CONS (ENT Consultation): 20 minutes.
* ENT-AUDI (Audiometry): 30 minutes.
* ENT-SEPT (Septoplasty): 90 minutes.

5. Patient Preparation Instructions

5.1 ENT-CONS (Consultation): Patients must bring a complete medication list, prior audiological reports dated within the past 12 months, and imaging discs (CT sinuses or neck) if completed outside the Meridian network.
5.2 ENT-AUDI (Audiometry): Patients must avoid exposure to loud noise (concerts, heavy machinery, firearms) for a minimum of 14 hours prior to the test. Headbands and heavy earrings must be removed upon check-in.
5.3 ENT-SEPT (Septoplasty): Patients must cease all anticoagulants, aspirin, and non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drugs (NSAIDs) exactly 7 days prior to the procedure date, under the direct supervision of their prescribing physician. Patients must maintain strict nil per os (NPO) status starting 8 hours before arrival.

6. Procedures and Insurance Plan Coverage

6.1 Meridian Health Partners maintains four health plan tiers. Coverage and pre-authorisation requirements for approved ENT service codes are strictly regulated as follows:

Service Code & Description	List Price	Plan Tier	Coverage Status	Pre-Authorisation Requirement
ENT-CONS ENT Consultation	$170	MERIDIAN-GOLD MERIDIAN-SILVER MERIDIAN-BRONZE CIVIC-BASE	Covered Covered Covered Covered	No pre-authorisation No pre-authorisation No pre-authorisation No pre-authorisation
ENT-AUDI Audiometry	$150	MERIDIAN-GOLD MERIDIAN-SILVER MERIDIAN-BRONZE CIVIC-BASE	Covered Covered Covered Covered	No pre-authorisation No pre-authorisation No pre-authorisation No pre-authorisation
ENT-SEPT Septoplasty	$5,400	MERIDIAN-GOLD MERIDIAN-SILVER MERIDIAN-BRONZE CIVIC-BASE	Covered Covered Covered Covered	Pre-authorisation in 2 business days Pre-authorisation in 3 business days Pre-authorisation in 5 business days Pre-authorisation in 7 business days

6.2 No deviations from the pre-authorisation timelines listed in Section 6.1 are permitted without written sign-off from Chief Medical Officer Dr. Aris Thorne.

End of Policy MHP-ENT-SH-042